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May 7, 2026

Kathy Petry
Gladys Brooks Foundation
1055 Franklin Avenue, Suite 208
Garden City, NY 11530

RE: Restoring Instructional School Library Services to Strengthen Media Literacy

Dear Ms. Petry:

Thanks for coming to my talk and learning more about this proposal. Today's students are increasingly navigating intricate digital information landscapes, frequently lacking adequate training in research and media literacy. About 88% of public schools say they have a media center, but the availability of fully staffed instructional programs is very different from school to school (Fast Facts: Libraries (42), n.d.). Consequently, numerous students find it difficult to assess sources, perform efficient research, and interact with academic material in significant manners (Berg et al., 2018).

This need fits well with the Gladys Brooks Foundation's mission to help schools and library-based projects that encourage intellectual growth. The Foundation's focus on making knowledge and learning more accessible is directly reflected in the way it improves school library programs by giving them better resources and instruction. The old library space at Bergen County Academies (BCA) has been turned into a computer lab, which makes it harder for students to get to both print materials and structured lessons. This proposal lays out a plan to bring back a library for learning by hiring a School Library Media Specialist, changing the space into a place for group research, and putting in place a structured media literacy curriculum. This project will need about \$121,770.86 to pay for redesigning the space, getting new materials, hiring staff, and putting the program into action. The Foundation would directly help students become better researchers, improve their literacy skills, and get ready for a digital world that is becoming more complicated by investing in this project.

Thank you for your time and thought, and I look forward to the chance to talk more about this proposal.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Joanna Rydzewski', written in a cursive style.

Joanna Rydzewski

Rebuilding Research: A Comprehensive Approach to Restoring Student Literacy Through Library Instruction in the Digital Age



(Source: Stanford Social Innovation Review)

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May 7, 2026

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Abstract

This proposal looks at how structured research and media literacy instruction at Bergen County Academies (BCA) has gotten worse. The loss of a dedicated library space has made it harder for students to learn important academic skills. Even though students can use digital resources, they are often expected to find their way around complicated information environments without any formal training. This makes it hard for them to understand what they are reading. Prior studies indicate that students frequently utilize superficial search strategies and encounter difficulties in assessing source credibility, particularly in contexts that are becoming more digital and reliant on algorithms. This project responds by suggesting the re-establishment of an instructional library program that includes a certified media specialist, structured media literacy education, and a new collaborative learning space. The project is based on successful ways of teaching in school libraries and focuses on guided research, critical thinking, and keeping students interested in reading for a long time. It says that putting direct instruction and a planned learning space together will help students better judge information and deal with complicated texts. Expected results are better reading comprehension, stronger research skills, and more interest in schoolwork. In the end, this proposal shows how important it is to bring back library programs that teach students how to use technology so they can succeed in a digital world.

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Statement of Need

The Decline of Media and Research Skills

For a long time, school libraries have been vital in helping students develop their research and reading skills, not just for completing assignments. High school students should be able to find, evaluate, and use information effectively, but these skills need direct instruction (Berg et al., 2018). It is critical to highlight that librarians act as teachers as they help learners identify credible sources and organize research material (Berg et al., 2018). The library setting promotes reading, thinking, and interaction processes that enhance students' academic success in the future (Godfree & Neilson, 2018). Formal teaching in information literacy acts as the foundation of any educational process since, as noted by Berg et al. (2018), "without foundations, we can't build," emphasizing that information literacy must be considered a fundamental step before proceeding further. It should be recognized that without this skill set, students cannot be involved in any academic discipline.

Even so, fewer people can use these programs. Between 2009 and 2016, more than 9,000 full-time school library jobs were cut across the country, which is a 15% drop (Morel, 2021). This trend is part of a larger change in how schools use their resources. They often see libraries as unnecessary, even though they are useful for teaching. Teachers have said that these cuts are "a huge, huge mistake" that will hurt student learning in the long run (Morel, 2021).

At the same time, students are expected to be able to find their way around complicated digital information without any help. Because there is so much content online and people read it so quickly, it is now very important to be able to tell the difference between credible and non-credible sources (Mesquita-Romero et al., 2022). However, learners tend to engage in superficial search behavior where they choose information based on its accessibility rather than its authenticity (Ilomäki et al., 2023). This is even more pronounced in artificial intelligence-powered search engines because they provide well-articulated responses that might not necessarily be accurate. This is especially true when learners have not been trained to evaluate the credibility and authenticity of information sources.

This worry is made worse by the general trend toward using digital media more. Digital literacy, which means being able to critically navigate and evaluate digital information, is now necessary for academic success (Akello, 2024). But there are still gaps in digital literacy, and these gaps are affected by how easy it is to get an education and technology (Akello, 2024). Even for students who use digital platforms a lot, high usage does not always mean they have good critical thinking or evaluation skills.

Nowadays, students tend to read smaller texts and faster-changing content. Such a trend makes it difficult for them to grasp and analyze the information they get (Loh & Sun, 2022). Research reveals that there is an adverse effect on learning when people adopt fragmentary reading practices (Salmerón et al., 2023). According to national tendencies, the number of readers is becoming less; therefore, the role of schools in such a situation grows (Perfas, 2025).

Local Impact: Bergen County Academies

These national trends can also be seen at Bergen County Academies (BCA) in Hackensack, NJ. The school's original library space has been turned into a computer lab, which means that there is no longer a separate place for reading, research, and guided instruction. Students still have access to technology, but they do not have a structured space that is meant to help them improve their reading and writing skills and their ability to think critically.

This is evident from the data obtained from local literacy rates. According to the report Best Bergen County Public High Schools (2026), the average reading level in the public high schools of Bergen County is 58%. Although the reading levels in the county are above the state's 47% average, they are lower than what students require. Meeting the state's standard is, therefore, inadequate to ensure students have all that it takes to succeed academically and in their life thereafter. Additionally, only 38% of the learners have ever been taught how to analyze the content of media messages. This indicates an important gap in media literacy education (Ayala Rios, 2024). This deficiency is likely to persist even in adulthood since nearly half of the population has stated that they were never taught such skills in school (Prothero, 2022).

In addition, the lack of a library as a separate entity is another factor that affects the study process. According to Kuwabara (2024), the outcomes of education are improved when learners engage in studies in an environment that promotes teamwork and learning through activities and not only via computer usage. The significance of school libraries has always been defined by their ability to serve as a medium for receiving help, collecting information, and communicating with each other (Godfree & Neilson, 2018).

BCA students must figure out hard things on their own without a space like this, and they often do not have the right tools to do it well. Not only does this hurt their grades, but it also makes it harder for them to learn important skills that they will need for the rest of their lives, like research, analysis, and critical thinking.

The Urgency of Action

This problem needs to be addressed immediately. As digital information continues to grow, the ability to evaluate sources critically is necessary for academic success and informed citizenship. This is made clear through the experience of students who engage in the digital world. A teacher has mentioned how “web of information where students can get lost or trapped with misinformation” (Morel, 2021). Being “lost” is very significant because it indicates that unless properly guided by teachers, students do not just make mistakes here and there; rather, they are prone to getting caught up in false information.

At the same time, expectations for education keep going up. Students are expected to do research, make arguments based on evidence, and deal with complicated information, but many of them have not been taught how to do these things in a formal way. This disconnect puts students at a disadvantage, especially in a world where false information is easy to find and hard to spot.

This problem gets worse because school library programs are going away. Studies have demonstrated that robust library programs are directly correlated with elevated literacy rates and enhanced academic performance, especially in institutions catering to diverse demographics (Morel, 2021). Taking away these programs takes away one of the few regular chances for students to learn how to use research and media.

It is very important to deal with this problem now to stop literacy and critical thinking from getting worse. This project directly meets both local and national needs by creating a dedicated library space and adding structured lessons in research and media literacy. It gives students the skills they need to deal with an information landscape that is getting more complicated all the time and makes sure they are ready for academic and professional challenges in the future.

Plan of Action

Guiding Framework and Research Foundation

Established models of effective school library programs, especially those that stress working together between librarians and classroom teachers, are what this project is based on. When librarians are actively involved in teaching, students learn better research skills because they get direct, structured help instead of having to figure things out on their own (Berg et al., 2018). These models show that having librarians help with classroom work lets students practice judging sources, putting together information, and making arguments in real time.

With this collaborative approach, students do not have to figure out research on their own. Instead, they get help right away with things like evaluating sources, organizing information, and making arguments. Studies show that this method greatly helps students get better at doing their own academic research over time (Godfree & Neilson, 2018).

Lessons from Proven Models of Media Literacy

The proposed framework for media literacy development draws upon previously created models by Berg et al. (2018) and Cannon et al. (2022), which focus on the need to provide structured and direct instruction related to critical thinking and evaluation of sources. This evidence suggests that students can become more skilled at distinguishing between accurate and unreliable information and developing thoughtful attitudes towards online content in a situation when there are direct lessons focused on media literacy. Such lessons can help learners detect bias, understand the nature of knowledge production, and critically evaluate different sources (Cannon et al., 2022). Moreover, Berg et al. (2018) found that students' skills in evaluating sources became better when they received structured lessons about information literacy. Based on these models, it is possible to assume that the current proposal will be successful since it includes direct instruction.

In practice, these models require students to do things like compare different sources, find false information, and trace content back to its original source (Mesquita-Romero et al., 2022). Studies indicate that students engaged in structured media literacy education exhibit enhanced critical

thinking abilities and greater success in discerning misinformation (Mesquita-Romero et al., 2022).

The need for such techniques has been further emphasized by the trend among students towards their engagement with information. Studies have found that students tend to use the first results of their searches without checking whether the source is reliable. Consequently, there is no critical thinking; only superficial comprehension occurs (Ilomäki et al., 2023). The strategy of the students is justified by the essence of digital media, which places more emphasis on quick access than comprehensive inquiry. Considering that there are many media types that students may encounter, from videos and podcasts to social media posts and long essays, instructions on evaluating all kinds of information sources are necessary. Digital literacy, defined as the ability to interact critically with any form of media, has become an essential competency (Akello, 2024).

Three Phase Implementation Plan

This project will be a pilot program for students in grades 9–12 at Bergen County Academies (BCA) that lasts for a whole school year (September–June). The plan is based on research that shows that good school library programs include librarian-led instruction in classes, structured media literacy education, and collaborative learning spaces that help students do better (Berg et al., 2018). These models demonstrate that students enhance their research and critical thinking abilities when instruction is integrated, explicit, and bolstered by an environment conducive to inquiry and collaboration (Godfree & Neilson, 2018).

BCA will put this framework into action by hiring a certified school library media specialist who will work with teachers on big projects. Students will get more consistent practice with important skills if research instruction is built into their coursework instead of just being taught occasionally. This approach is in line with the bigger goal of school libraries, which is not just to give people access to materials but also to make sure they have access to "high-quality, reliable information" and the skills they need to use it well (Morel, 2021).

Phase 1: Infrastructure and Staffing (Summer-Early Fall)

The current computer lab will be turned into a library with areas for working together, reading alone, and teaching in the middle. This redesign is based on research that shows that flexible learning environments get students more involved and interested than computer-based ones (Kuwabara, 2024). As part of this process, the money will be used to buy a wide range of books, both fiction and non-fiction, as well as reference books like encyclopedias. This will make sure that students have access to high-quality academic and independent reading materials. There will also be bookshelves, a circulation desk, and tools for organizing things put in place to make the learning space more structured and easier to get to.

At the same time, a certified School Library Media Specialist (SLMS) will be hired to teach and work with teachers. This job is very important because research shows that students do better when librarians are directly involved in teaching and making assignments instead of doing them on their own (Berg et al., 2018). The SLMS will also work with faculty during this phase to

make sure that research expectations are the same across departments and to make instructional materials ready for use (American Library Association, 2020).

Phase 2: Curriculum Integration and Instruction (Fall–Winter)

Based on research that shows that integration leads to better skill development (Mesquita-Romero et al., 2022), media literacy will be taught as part of the curriculum at all grade levels instead of as a separate unit. The lessons will be different for each grade level:

- Grades 9-10: Students will have to go to research workshops that teach them basic skills like how to evaluate sources, use databases, and spot bias.
- Grades 11-12: Students will learn about long-term research projects, including capstone work, with a focus on how to tell if a source is credible, how to combine information from different sources, and how to judge information that was created by AI.

The SLMS will collaborate on classroom instruction in English, history, and STEM lessons to provide opportunities for students to utilize research and media literacy skills in classwork. This will create contextual opportunities for applying these skills rather than practicing them separately. It can be shown from studies that cooperation between librarians and teachers has a positive effect on the students' ability to conduct independent scholarly research (Godfree & Neilson, 2018). Reading programs will be initiated to promote reading motivation and comprehension using sustained silent reading sessions and discussion facilitated through the availability of a larger number of books (Perfas, 2025). Nevertheless, to ensure that students do not only stay passive during the period of sustained silent reading but also engage in reading, short assessments, including reading journals, exit slips, or quick one-to-one interviews will be used by the SLMS. It was shown in studies that this practice leads to greater reading comprehension than random digital reading (Salmerón et al., 2023).

Teachers will go to professional development sessions to learn how to include media literacy and research skills in their lessons. This will make sure that all subjects are taught the same way. This training makes sure that all the students get the same kind of lessons in all their subjects and helps them learn how to do research that they can use in other areas.

Phase 3: Program Implementation and Refinement (Winter-Spring)

In the second half of the year, the program will move toward full implementation and ongoing improvement. The SLMS will offer continuous, integrated research assistance for significant assignments, especially for upperclassmen involved in independent or extended projects, emphasizing the significance of guided inquiry in academic achievement (Berg et al., 2018). The SLMS will also take care of the library's collection, making sure that resources are always useful and available to students.

The remodeled library area will work as a learning place where collaboration, discussion, and self-directed inquiry will take place by the learners based on research that suggests such spaces improve engagement and academic performance (Kuwabara, 2024). The learning about media literacy will continue emphasizing the aspects of analyzing biases, verifying facts, and evaluating the information produced using artificial intelligence, given the importance of education in the discussed areas when it comes to navigating today's information environments (Mesquita-Romero et al., 2022). The assistance and guidance of teachers will be ongoing as it is necessary

to ensure that their lessons remain coherent and facilitate the development of sustainable digital competencies (Ilomäki et al., 2023). Finally, the program will continue changing based on data about the progress and level of engagement of the learners (Godfree & Neilson, 2018).

Expected Outcomes and Measures of Success

Evaluating the success of this project will involve employing both quantitative and qualitative approaches centered around the primary aims of the program, including developing better research abilities, increased media literacy, and improved reading practices. The development of research ability will be measured by evaluating a selected number of research assignments submitted by students in each class involved in the project every trimester during the school year, in conjunction with their respective teachers. These assignments will be assessed using a set of criteria related to assessing reliable sources, conducting an appropriate level of analysis, and utilizing citations appropriately (Berg et al., 2018).

Student skills and engagement will also be measured through pre- and post-program surveys administered digitally via Google Forms at the start and end of each semester. The surveys will have questions about the students' level of confidence in finding sources, judging the credibility of these sources, and analyzing the information, all of which can be attributed to building digital literacy skills (Ilomäki et al., 2023). The SLMS will then use the results of these surveys to find trends and determine where more work is needed. Reading interest will be measured through attendance at library programs, the number of books borrowed from the new library collection, and other reading programs (Perfas, 2025). Teachers will provide qualitative feedback through short reflections at the end of each semester about changes they notice in students' research habits and critical thinking (Godfree & Neilson, 2018).

The criteria for success in terms of this project can be considered improvements of students' research works, more usage of credible sources, their critical evaluation, and overall increase in reading engagement. These factors should show whether it was worth investing in such a project or not. In general, further actions might relate to improving this project or even implementing it elsewhere.

Budget

Initial Implementation Costs

Direct Costs			
	Unit Cost	Quantity	Total Cost
Personnel			
School Library Media Specialist	\$ 66,000.00	1	\$ 66,000.00
Maintenance Staff	\$ -	15	\$ -
Teaching Staff	\$ -	93	\$ -
Total Personnel	\$ 66,000.00	109	\$ 66,000.00
Supplies			
Total Books	\$ 1,385.28	7001	\$ 26,471.40
Total Miscellaneous	\$ 1,366.66	160	\$ 20,389.46
Total Supplies	\$ 2,751.94	7161	\$ 46,860.86
Contractors			
Training	\$ 1,750.00	1	\$ 1,750.00
Assembly	\$ 179.00	40	\$ 7,160.00
Curriculum	\$ -	4	\$ -
Total Contractors	\$ 1,929.00	45	\$ 8,910.00
Total	\$ 70,680.94	7315	\$ 121,770.86

Table 1

As outlined in Table 1, which details each item by quantity and unit cost to produce a line-item total with each section then summed to give a total cost per category, and with a further breakdown of supply costs provided in the Supplies section below, the project is expected to cost \$121,770.86 in total, with personnel costs making up 54.20% of that, supplies costs making up 38.48%, and contracts costs making up 7.32%. The biggest part of the budget goes to people, which shows how important it is to hire a full-time School Library Media Specialist to lead instruction, manage resources, and help students learn. This focus on staffing shows that the project's success depends not only on materials, but also on regular, expert teaching of media literacy and research skills (Berg et al., 2018).

The 38.48% set aside for supplies shows that the library collection and the physical learning space both need to be rebuilt. Based on bulk buying and vendor pricing, this category's funding goes to books (\$26,471.20) and library infrastructure (\$20,389.46). This part of the budget makes sure that students have access to a variety of reading materials and a well-organized space for working together and doing research, both of which are important for getting students more interested in reading (Perfas, 2025). The last 7.32% of the budget goes to contracts for specific outside services, like training teachers and putting together furniture. This lets the project run smoothly without putting too much strain on internal staff.

Personnel

The \$66,000.00 personnel budget ([Glassdoor.com, 2025](https://www.glassdoor.com)) is all going toward hiring a full-time School Library Media Specialist, who is the most important person for this project to succeed.

This salary estimate is based on the average pay for similar jobs in the area, which makes sure the job is competitive and can draw in a qualified candidate. The School Library Media Specialist will teach students how to use media, help them with their research, manage the library's resources, and work with teachers to make sure that students learn how to use information in their assignments. These duties are a direct response to the needs outlined in the proposal, especially the need for more structured research instruction and help with evaluating digital information.

There are no extra costs for hiring teachers or maintenance staff because they already work for Bergen County Academies and will help with the project in their current roles. To add research instruction to their classes, teachers will work with the media specialist. Maintenance staff will help keep the space clean. The project keeps costs down by using current employees, but it still makes sure that everything is done. It's important to invest in a dedicated SLMS because research shows that schools without trained library staff often do not teach information literacy in a structured way, which means that students have trouble evaluating sources and doing academic research well (American Library Association, 2020).

Supplies

	Unit Cost	Quantity	Total Cost
Supplies			
Books:			
Fiction Books:			
Fantasy	\$ 3.50	625	\$ 2,187.50
Mystery	\$ 2.75	625	\$ 1,718.75
Science Fiction	\$ 3.30	625	\$ 2,062.50
Historical Fiction	\$ 6.33	625	\$ 3,958.33
Other	\$ 2.91	1000	\$ 2,906.25
Total Fiction Books	\$ 18.79	3500	\$ 12,833.33
Non-Fiction Books:			
Biographies	\$ 3.38	625	\$ 2,109.38
History	\$ 3.55	625	\$ 2,218.75
True Crime	\$ 3.75	625	\$ 2,343.75
Business	\$ 3.19	625	\$ 1,992.19
Other	\$ 3.63	1000	\$ 3,625.00
Total Non-fiction Books	\$ 17.49	3500	\$ 12,289.06
Encyclopedias	\$ 1,349.00	1	\$ 1,349.00
Total Books	\$ 1,385.28	7001	\$ 26,471.40
Miscellaneous:			
Bookshelves	\$ 483.10	40	\$ 19,324.00
Book Cart	\$ 181.90	2	\$ 363.80
Circulation Desk	\$ 701.66	1	\$ 701.66
Tables	\$ -	21	\$ -
Chairs	\$ -	81	\$ -
Desktop Computers	\$ -	15	\$ -
Total Miscellaneous	\$ 1,366.66	160	\$ 20,389.46
Total Supplies	\$ 2,751.94	7161	\$ 46,860.86

Table 2

As broken down in Table 2, which details each item, its quantity, unit price, and total cost, the \$46,860.86 budget for supplies is split between buying books for a full library and setting up a space for learning. Of this total, 27.39% goes to fiction books, 26.22% goes to non-fiction books, 2.88% goes to encyclopedias, and 43.51% goes to other types of infrastructure. This distribution shows a good balance between encouraging people to read and making sure the space works well as a library. The \$26,471.40 set aside for books includes \$12,833.33 for fiction, which includes fantasy (\$2,187.50) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-a](#)), mystery (\$1,718.75) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-b](#)), science fiction (\$2,906.25) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-c](#)), historical fiction (\$3,958.33) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-d](#)), and other fiction categories (\$2,062.50) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-e](#)). This is based on bulk pricing from Book Depot. The total for non-fiction is \$12,289.06. This includes biographies (\$2,109.38) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-f](#)), history (\$2,218.75) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-g](#)), true crime (\$2,343.75) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-h](#)), business (\$1,992.19) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-i](#)), and other non-fiction categories (\$3,625.00) ([BookDepot.com, n.d.-j](#)). The prices are based on bulk pricing from Book Depot. A set of encyclopedias ([Amazon.com, n.d.-a](#)) costs an extra \$1,349.00, which makes sure that people can get basic reference materials. This distribution makes sure that students can get both interesting reading materials and resources that are useful for school, which helps them improve their reading and research skills (Perfas, 2025).

The other 43.51% (\$20,389.46) goes toward setting up the library space. This includes 40 bookshelves that cost \$19,324.00 ([HomeDepot.com, 2026](#)), a circulation desk that costs \$701.66 ([Thelibrarystore.com, 2026](#)), and two book carts that cost \$363.80 ([Amazon.com, n.d.-b](#)). The current computer lab's tables, chairs, and computers will be reused, which will save money and still let the space be redesigned into a place where people can work together to learn. This allocation makes sure that the biggest part of the supplies budget goes toward infrastructure, which is necessary to turn the space into a working library that encourages students to use it for academic purposes (Kuwabara, 2024).

Contracts

The \$8,910.00 contracts budget pays for outside services that are needed to make the program work well. Teachers will get \$1,750.00 for professional development training ([NewsLit.com, 2026](#)), which will focus on how to use media literacy and research in the classroom. This cost is for structured training programs that will help teachers teach students how to evaluate digital information and improve their critical thinking skills. This is directly in line with the proposal's instructional goals (Mesquite-Romero et al., 2022).

There is an extra \$7,160.00 set aside for the professional assembly of 40 bookshelves ([HomeDepot.com, 2026](#)). Because of how big the library setup is, hiring someone else to put it together makes sure that the space is built quickly and safely, which keeps the project on track. No extra money is set aside for curriculum development because the School Library Media Specialist is already trained to create and teach media literacy and research skills. This makes sure that the development of the curriculum is both cost-effective and directly meets the needs of BCA students while still supporting the project's teaching goals (Ilomäki et al., 2023).

Long-Term Sustainability Plan

Direct Costs			
	Unit Cost	Quantity	Total Cost
Personnel			
School Library Media Specialist	\$ 66,000.00	1	\$ 66,000.00
Maintenance Staff	\$ -	15	\$ -
Teaching Staff	\$ -	93	\$ -
Total Personnel	\$ 66,000.00	109	\$ 66,000.00
Supplies			
Books:			
Fiction Books:			
Fantasy	\$ 3.50	10	\$ 35.00
Mystery	\$ 2.75	10	\$ 27.50
Science Fiction	\$ 3.30	10	\$ 33.00
Historical Fiction	\$ 6.33	10	\$ 63.33
Other	\$ 2.91	20	\$ 58.13
Total Fiction Books	\$ 18.79	60	\$ 216.96
Non-Fiction Books:			
Biographies	\$ 3.38	10	\$ 33.75
History	\$ 3.55	10	\$ 35.50
True Crime	\$ 3.75	10	\$ 37.50
Business	\$ 3.19	10	\$ 31.88
Other	\$ 3.63	20	\$ 72.50
Total Non-fiction Books	\$ 17.49	60	\$ 211.13
Donations	\$ -	100	\$ -
Total Books	\$ 36.28	220	\$ 428.08
Total Supplies	\$ 36.28	220	\$ 428.08
Contractors			
Training	\$ 1,750.00	1	\$ 1,750.00
Curriculum	\$ -	4	\$ -
Total Contractors	\$ 1,750.00	5	\$ 1,750.00
Total	\$ 67,786.28	334	\$ 68,178.08

Table 3

As detailed in Table 3, the estimated yearly cost of keeping the program going after the first year is about \$68,178.08, with most of that going to staff. The SLMS's \$66,000.00 salary is still the most important investment, showing that there is a need for consistent, expert instruction in research and media literacy. The district will have to pay for the salary in future years, even though this position is initially funded by a grant. This will make sure that the position lasts beyond the grant period. The budget moves away from big setup costs and toward keeping the quality of instruction and daily operations up after the first year, when the physical space, furniture, and core collection are already in place. The current teaching and maintenance staff will continue to support the program in their current roles, so there will not be any extra staff costs other than the specialist position.

The annual cost of maintaining the library books is quite minimal, standing at \$428.08 in total. The money will cater for books on both fiction (\$216.96) and non-fiction (\$211.13) with the objective of ensuring that the students continue to show interest in the library and that there is satisfaction of their academic requirements. There will only be a select acquisition of library items, hence serving some purposes. The purpose may vary between leisure reading materials and conducting intensive research in their studies. In addition to the cost of purchasing library books, there will be 100 library books received annually through the donations scheme of the school.

The last \$1,750.00 goes to contracts that help teachers keep learning and growing as professionals. This makes sure that media literacy and research instruction stay well-integrated across all subject areas. The SLMS will update and improve the curriculum as part of their job, so no extra money is needed for this. Overall, the lower yearly budget shows that the project can last for a long time because the initial investments are turning into a cost-effective model based on staffing, maintenance, and gradual growth.

Discussion

Bridging the Gap Between Access and Understanding

BCA students have unrestricted access to technology and media sources. Despite having unrestricted access, the lack of proper training has failed to generate adequate media literacy and research abilities among BCA students (Ilomäki et al., 2023). In the absence of proper training, students need to handle complicated information without any guidance. As a result, they choose convenience over authenticity while sourcing information (Ilomäki et al., 2023). The problem is further compounded with the rise of artificial intelligence (AI) and algorithms generating content based on the source's popularity irrespective of its veracity (Mesquita-Romero et al., 2022). Short-form media's growing popularity is making students incapable of handling complicated information and adversely affecting their reading skills (Salmerón et al., 2023; Loh & Sun, 2022).

The proposed project seeks to address the above issues through the re-introduction of the library setting and provision of guided instruction to the BCA learners, who are academically gifted yet have a substantial gap when it comes to research and media literacy skills. The project is aimed at bridging the knowledge gap by helping the learners acquire the necessary skills to help them analyze information effectively. According to Berg et al. (2018), achievement in any discipline is reliant on the presence of adequate foundational skills, which should form the backbone of the proposed project.

The Role of Schools in a Digital Society

With the increasing availability of information and its subsequent difficulty in assessment, educational institutions are required to do much more than merely providing facts. Educating students on the skills of critical analysis is necessary to function effectively in a highly sophisticated digital environment. In an age where media literacy has become imperative for both academic achievement and active participation in civic life, it is evident that insufficient

attention is being paid to media literacy education within schools (Cannon et al., 2022). Only a small percentage of students have been reported to receive media literacy training, while many adults admit to lacking such abilities entirely, indicating that this problem does not disappear with time (Ayala Rios, 2024; Prothero, 2022). The school library system can play a crucial role in bridging this gap, but the recent decrease in the number of library programs has hindered this possibility (Godfree & Neilson, 2018; American Library Association, 2020).

However, at BCA, there is no library space currently existing. Therefore, it can be said that the students are missing out on being able to be in a place where such skills can be acquired effectively. According to Kuwabara (2024), students do well if they are in a collaborative environment compared to an environment which focuses only on technological aspects. The library redesigning plan is going to solve this problem by converting the library space into a classroom environment.

Long-Term Impact on Students and Communities

This initiative is bound to bring about numerous positive changes which are not just limited to addressing the research and media literacy needs. Through imparting critical thinking and evaluation skills, this will help equip BCA students with all the necessary knowledge to succeed in their academic and professional life in the future. As per various studies, students benefit from learning in an environment that combines collaboration and resources rather than simply relying on the availability of advanced technologies (Kuwabara, 2024). Unfortunately, BCA still does not have a library facility, thus making this project even more crucial.

This initiative promotes educational equity in the sense that it attempts to rectify inequalities that arise because of differential access to formal learning environments. Digital literacy is dependent on access to learning materials and proper guidance, but not all learners start on even ground (Akello, 2024). Through this initiative, which guarantees each BCA student access to quality guidance in a learning environment such as a library, the inequality gap will be addressed.

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